

1930–1944

# ROMANTIC NOSTALGIA

There seems to be a limit to the amount of modernity and restraint fashion can endure. *Robes de style* (with loose bodices, dropped waists, and full skirts) had preserved prettiness and the traditional idea of femininity throughout the 1920s. Now diaphanous concoctions trimmed with an abundance of frills, ruffles, and lace became popular with those too young, too old, or not streamlined enough to squeeze their bodies into an unforgiving lamé or satin sheath. Adrian's design for Joan Crawford playing Letty Lynton in the eponymous 1932 film is widely credited with starting this trend. Deflated versions of the gigantic ruffled sleeves of the star's dress of white *mousseline de soie* (a thin fabric made of silk or rayon) remained fashionable until the end of the decade, and even crept into Walter Plunkett's costume designs for *Gone with the Wind* in 1939. Britain's Queen Elizabeth gave her royal seal of approval when she wore her famous "White Wardrobe", a series of romantic gowns based on Winterhalter paintings during a state visit to Paris in 1938.



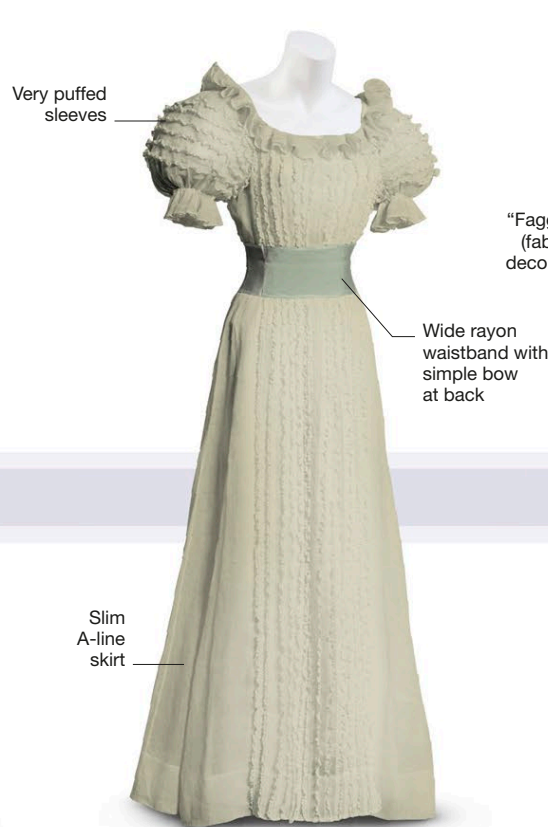
1932

**Debutante look** This high-waisted gown of Devonshire silk net in love-in-a-mist blue would have been considered more appropriate as eveningwear than a clinging dress for a young, unmarried woman.



1937

**Flower trail** French designer Lanvin opted for a more sophisticated romanticism avoiding puff sleeves, ruffles, or lace. The prettiness of the flowers in different shades of pink that seem to be encircling the wearer's body is counteracted by the use of black for the tendrils or branches.



**Nostalgia** Chanel's white cotton evening dress, with its slim silhouette, puffed sleeves, and low neckline, is reminiscent of Edwardian fashion. Narrow rows of delicate ruching add to the nostalgic feel of the 1937 design.



**Fragility** French designer Vionnet has not only used a lingerie technique for some of the decorative seams of this gown, but also a colour that was fashionable for delicate underwear. The covered décolletage, elbow-length sleeves, and wide skirt contradict this association.